

INSIDE NASA'S MISSION CONTROL CENTRE



Always been fascinated with the idea of space travel? Well this

extremely-detailed Ars Technica article goes behind the scenes of NASA's Mission Control Centre where Apollo veteran Seymour Liebergot plays guide.
<http://dgit.in/SfTfpd>

WAR FOR TV

This series on The Verge takes a look at the future of TV and how relevant is cable TV with all the various media-player ecosystems around. The week-long series has interviews with industry experts and reviews of various ecosystems such as Microsoft, Google, Apple, Sony and so on.
<http://dgit.in/T6yCe7>

SOCIAL MEDIA (NON) ECONOMY 101



Next time you come across anyone addressing himself or herself

as a Social Media Catalyst or Social Media Consultant or Social Media Accelerator, simply show them this video. A hilarious take on the social media economy.
<http://dgit.in/ThEWlv>

INSIDE GOOGLE NOW

With Jelly Bean 4.1 Google introduced us to the virtual search assistant – Google Now which gets intelligent over time as you use Google and gives you cards with relevant information even before you ask for it. This piece takes an in-depth look at how it was conceptualised and what you can expect in the future.
<http://dgit.in/UpWTOf>

And then there's the marketing — oh boy is Microsoft plowing a lot into marketing. As you may already know, Microsoft's marketing budget for Windows 8, Surface, and Windows Phone 8 is somewhere in the region of \$1.5-\$2 billion. Most of this will be consumed by blanket advertising on TV, websites, and in magazines — but, in a first for the mobile OS wars, Microsoft is also forking out on celebrity endorsements.

THE FALL OF THE WINDOWS/ OFFICE HEGEMONY

While Windows Phone 7's failure has been buoyed up by Windows 7's success over the last few years, it's now time for the mantle to be passed to Windows 8 and Windows Phone 8. With desktop PC sales stagnant, and tablets and smartphones on a meteoric rise, Microsoft really needs Windows 8 and WP8 to succeed. If Microsoft can't break into the smartphone and tablet markets with this generation of software, it may not get another chance.

For Microsoft, this must be rather scary. For decades, Windows and Office have been the driving forces behind the company — and now, in just a single generation, this partnership has forced apart by an unproven trifecta; a triumvirate of Windows 8, Windows Phone 8, and Xbox.

To date, almost all of Microsoft's business decisions have revolved around the monopolization of maximization of Windows and Office — resulting in oodles of profit, but a severe lack of innovation. Such navel-gazing was fine when PCs were exciting and expensive and enjoying massive sales growth, but in the last 10 years such complacency has mostly resulted in Microsoft attempting to strut about with its pants tangled around its ankles.

Microsoft rather famously dropped the ball with the world wide web, and it certainly



wasn't ready for Apple's creation of both the smartphone and tablet markets. So the rumor goes, Microsoft had a tablet in development — called the Courier — but it was kiboshed by Steven Sinofsky, then head of Windows, just before Apple released the iPad.

The irony is, Microsoft has one of the largest and best-funded R&D departments in the world, working on everything from depth-sensing cameras to muscle-computer interfaces. With the dissipation of the Windows and Office's oppression, though, we have started to see a lot of cool tech from Microsoft Research finally start hitting the market (Kinect, Surface/PixelSense, Gadgets, and so on). This is a good thing, and it shows that there's life in the old dog yet.

WINDOWS PHONE 8 CANNOT FAIL

Microsoft is in a precarious position: On the one hand, Windows and Office account for the vast majority of its profits — but on the other, these profits won't last forever. For the time being, the PC market is only being nibbled at by tablets and smartphones, but in a few years, as performance and wireless connectivity improves, the evisceration will begin in earnest. Microsoft knows this, and Windows Phone 8 and Windows 8 are the result.

Producing two operating systems that completely downplay Office, its largest profit

maker, is a monumental risk for Microsoft that must not fail.

The question, then, is whether Windows 8 and Windows Phone 8 can win Microsoft a spot at the mobile device table. Not a pesky 3 per cent share — a real, 20-30 per cent that will equate to hundreds of millions of new users in the next few years.

Can Microsoft do it? I'm not sure. Windows 8 is an excellent tablet operating system, but its ecosystem is a major letdown. Windows Phone 8 could well be the best mobile OS out there, but it will take a miracle to slow down the Android juggernaut or to steal users away from iOS. My main concern, though, is that Microsoft's chief selling point is the tight integration between its three platforms — SkyDrive sync, Windows Account roaming, and Xbox SmartGlass to bring the living room into the equation.

The problem with this approach is that it implies that adopters of one operating system will also adopt the other. In Apple's case, there is very little evidence that iOS has driven massive numbers of Mac sales; best case, we're talking a few million Mac laptops — not the hundreds of millions that Microsoft needs.

On the flip side, maybe the other direction — from PC to smartphone — is more fruitful. Microsoft is virtually guaranteed that hundreds of millions of PCs will run Windows 8 by this time next year. Maybe touch-enabled Windows 8 PCs will fly off the shelves this winter and fuel some kind of Windows Phone 8 renaissance in the spring. It's definitely possible — but given the importance of Windows and Windows Phone 8, it's an incredible gamble. But who knows: After 20 years of waking up, squeezing the udders of the Windows/Office cash cow, and then dozing off again, maybe a big gamble is exactly what Microsoft needs.